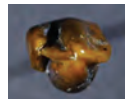




A Dolphin's token of love

Australian bottlenose dolphins were recently observed to offer sea sponges to female dolphins in a bid to woo them. <http://dgit.in/DolphnGft>



New mystery primate

A tooth discovered at a fossil site in Germany likely belonged to a very distant branch on the primate family tree. <http://dgit.in/ancprim>



Is it really a launch?

Getting your foot in the door seems to be a common strategy with technology launches, and it's becoming quite irritating.

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e've seen this happening quite frequently these days. A product is set to launch in a couple of

months, the PR machinery kicks in, everyone get aboard the hype-train till the moment of launch and then we hear of a few delays leading to the postponement of the launch by a couple of months. And when it does come time for the launch, we either get to see a stop gap measure introduced or, if we're lucky, the actual product. In the latter scenario, it generally ends up being a poor launch crippled by low yields, and subsequently, low stock. So can we really deem these as product launches? Not quite so.

It's been the case with any company that you can think of which isn't dealing with commoditised goods. So CPUs, GPUs and mobile phones seem to be the worst offenders. AMD's Ryzen and Vega 64 launch, NVIDIA's flagship pascal cards and now, Intel's Coffee Lake, all have left a poor taste in my mouth. I'm pretty certain, you all feel the same. You probably have better odds of getting electrocuted by lightning than getting your hands on any of these products at launch.

While NVIDIA seems to not be that big a failure when it comes to product launches, we can't say the same for Intel or AMD. Intel's Coffee Lake CPUs are hard to come by, even after nearly



a month post launch. And if we are to look at what AMD did with their Vega 64 bundles and "launch-pricing" then it gets even worse. However, it seems companies can't help it. All of these failed launches have been by publicly-traded companies, i.e., they have stockholders to answer to. When these companies unveil launch roadmaps at investor meets, they have to stick to those deadlines. If not, investors lose faith and then the stock prices tumble and you know how deep the rabbit hole goes. Simply put, not launching a product on time results in major losses for the company which apparently, is worse than consumers losing faith. We've started seeing a lot more stop gap measures or rebadges over the years for this very reason.

For enthusiasts and early adopters, this is a massive inconvenience. And



Intel's Coffee Lake Core i7

feeling betrayed is quite common. NVIDIA's GPU launches evoked that feeling quite well. Those who'd invested in the 980 Ti were banging their heads on the wall when the 1000 series Pascal cards were launched since the performance gap was enormous with miniscule change in price. And then they had a couple of flagships launching in quick succession with barely a few months between each launch. Everyone who bought a GTX 1080 felt cheated when the 1080 Ti came out for the exact same price. Those who'd invested in the Titan X had a similar experience with the Titan Xp launch.

For the community as a whole, there was a silver lining. These launches were great as it meant that incremental updates would come to an end. And incremental updates were a result of a lack of competition. I'm